Global Trends

With a special focus on the 10/40 Window

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Introduction:

There are many new trends in missions Today. We are living in a day of perhaps the most unprecedented activity of God in the history of the church. There are many changes, many paradigm shifts taking place as we approach the year 2000 and beyond. It is very difficult to highlight some of the trends to the exclusion of others.

When secular author John Naisbitt select ten mega trends in his bestselling book called “Mega Trends 2000,” it came out of an extensive process of reading newspapers, magazines from many sources, observing which subjects are repeated, compiling those into categories then prioritizing them into ten major trends.

My approach has been to reflect on major evangelical movements of our day suggesting emerging trends. I have summarized these into three main trends related to the three major players in the spiritual struggle of the ages, God, Satan and the global Christian community of believers.

The primary focus of the move of God, Satan and the church are in relation to the 10/40 Window. Why the 10/40 Window? Because the core of the unreached people of our world live in this rectangular-shaped window! Often called "The Resistant Belt", the window extends from West Africa to East Asia, from ten to forty degrees north of the equator. This specific region, which has increasingly become known as the 10/40 Window, encompasses the majority of the world's Muslims, Hindus, and Buddhists – literally billions of spiritually impoverished souls.

Even secularist John Naisbitt admits we are living in a time of unprecedented global revival. In his follow-up to the 1982 bestseller, Megatrends, he writes about the tenth of the Megatrends from the previous book and calls his new book: "Religious Revival of the Third Millennium." In it he describes the "unmistakable
signs of a worldwide multi-denominational religious revival."

The "God is dead" philosophy of the sixties is being quickly replaced. "With the millennium in sight, the powerful countertrend of the religious revival is repudiating blind faith in science and technology."

Huge increases have been experienced in church membership, especially among Evangelical, Charismatic and Pentecostal denominations. A "global phenomenon" is taking place that will replace modernism and a reliance on science; "the ideal of progress has given way to the return of faith."

As we consider a secular (IS SECULAR THE RIGHT WORD?) perspective, such as how do the major players manifest in the global drama of redemption, I would suggest that there are three major trends to watch out for today: the Move of the Holy Spirit, the Move of Satan and the Move of God’s people in the 10/40 Window.

I. The Move of the Holy Spirit in the 10/40 Window

A. Open doors for the gospel

Paul wrote to the church in Colossae, “And pray for us, too, that God may open a door for our message, so that we may proclaim the mystery of Christ.” (Col. 4:3). And God answers today as with Paul, when he wrote to the Corinthians: “But I will stay on at Ephesus until Pentecost, 9 because a great door for effective work has opened to me.” (1 Cor. 16:8) Sometimes the Holy Spirit did not open the door as in Acts 16:6; Paul and his companions …, having been kept by the Holy Spirit from preaching the word in the province of Asia.

Today the Holy Spirit is opening the doors in the 10/40 Window. One of the largest ministries in the Arab World reported earlier this month. “Truly the Lord has amazed us with the unprecedented ways He has been working during these past few years, and especially in opening new doors for ministry and is there anything greater than a wide-open door for the proclamation of the gospel?”

It is a fact that this is a time of harvest, and we know that the Lord ‘s servants who labored before us prayed for this very thing: "Lord, open doors for your gospel." And we are following up where they labored. It would be a great tragedy if we did not work night and day to accomplish what is on the heart of the Lord. I say in all sincerity that I can hardly believe what I am seeing every day. Muslims and nominal Christians are continuing to come every day to find out more about Christ, to ask questions, to discuss. And as a result, many believe and become Christians.

In the Arabian Peninsula Saudi citizens have invested literally billions of dollars in the development of international satellite television. 70% of all homes by the end of 1997 have a dish and an estimated 90,000 new homes get their first satellite dish every month. All this despite the fact that satellite dishes are officially illegal in Saudi Arabia! Satellite television has become a wide-open door for the proclamation of the gospel in the Arab World. 1997 was the second year of operation for a major evangelical cooperative satellite initiative with broadcast hours rising from 2 hours a week to 9 hours per week by next month.

B. People are responding to the gospel in the 10/40 Window

In a ministry in Jordan it was reported this month that more than 65,000 have responded since they started advertising in different newspapers and magazines the offering to send for free a Bible.

At the Cairo International Bookfair which took place in February the challenges were great. Several staff got very sick during the fair (fainting, broken ankle, food poisoning, exhaustion). Distribution permits were never received. Unlike their predictions however, all Christian stands reported very good sales. “We were overwhelmed by the unexpected response to God’s Word and praise God for his faithfulness.”

Just imagine the scene with dozens of people wanting to buy Scriptures and the lights flickering on and off warning that closing time had arrived. Disappointment on people’s faces was noticeable when they were told they could not buy more Scriptures.

In Egypt a Christian leader described the overwhelming response to an international evangelist who had been invited to come to Cairo. “The service was supposed to begin at 7 pm, and in Egypt this meant that most people would arrive around 7:30! So, you can imagine my surprise when I arrived on time only to

find dozens of people walking AWAY from the church!"

Hundreds of people were in the street trying to make their way through the gate into the church and were being told that there was no more room. The place was absolutely packed. The pastor was introducing the Evangelist; he reminded the audience that he would have a nightly hearing of more people than would fit in the large Cairo soccer stadium!

Through an ingenious program developed by this particular church, the complete service is videotaped and after the service dozens of people work all night to make hundreds of duplicate videos. Early the next morning, couriers travel to all parts of Egypt to deliver one or more tapes to the 570 churches that have agreed to take part in this outreach!! It is expected that around 150,000 participated each day.

World attention remains focused on the "Holy Land" in their struggle for peace and possession of the Holy sites in Hebron, Nablus and Jerusalem. An even more dramatic and exciting observation captures the attention of Christian believers. Receptivity to the Gospel message of the saving power of God in Jesus Christ increased in the aftermath of the Gulf War.

A long-term servant in the Holy Lands in his manuscript on what is happening in the region wrote: "Evangelical Christians from numerous churches and organizations mounted a concerted effort of "Praying through the 10-40 Window" … which included the majority of the Muslim world population. The Palestinian Authority, Jordan and other Middle East countries felt the impact of these prayers." For the first time in recent memory Muslims are beginning to accept the Gospel and the power of the written Word. They seek fellowship with Christians to learn how to pray and to worship God in new ways. … Now, with the dawning of the twenty first century, the fire of the Holy Spirit breaks out again, fanned by the praise of numerous believers of all nationalities in assemblies, house churches and traditional churches all over…"

Even in North Africa the Holy Spirit is moving in the hearts of people. One Algerian teenager wrote to the TV program "I would like to become a Christian. How can I do this?" A man from Morocco wrote "My friend has a satellite dish and has been corresponding with you. When he came to visit me, I noticed a big change in his personality – great happiness and peace of soul. He tried to explain what happened, but I understood nothing other than he now believes in Jesus. That is why I am writing you. I am eager to know more about the Christian faith and about Jesus."

Global researchers have in recent years been tracking what they call "The geo-response rate to the gospel." How do you measure response? Take the number of converts to Christ each year in any particular people, country or ethnic group and divide it by the amount of evangelism they have had from all sources. When you do that you come to the surprising conclusion that in all the 10/40 Window Peoples this ratio is vastly higher than outside the Window. You ask how much more responsive. They are "100 times more responsive."

C. Spectacular growth of the Christian community in the 10/40 Window countries

We have all heard about the remarkable growth of the church in China estimated to have grown from one million back in 1949 to 75 million today. But how about Nepal with a reported 75 known believers in the late 1970's to an estimated 500,000 today, from almost no churches to some 6000 churches and small house fellowships.

What about **Mongolia**? I remember meeting a woman at the Asian Missions Conference held in 1990. I

listened amazed as she told her story. She thought she was probably one of a handful of Mongolian believers in the entire country. Yet from just a handful a report from Ulan Bator in January of this year indicates that the Mongolian church has exploded to 10,000.

However, In **Iran,** prior to the Islamic Revolution Christian missions had established 37 evangelical churches. However, in 1979 all Western missionaries were expelled. Despite or because of increasing persecution, there has been phenomenal church growth. In 1977 there were 3,000 Christians, in 1996 that number had grown to 20,000 known Christians of which at least half are converts from Islam. There are an estimated 100,000 secret believers with several underground churches.

Not that many years ago the churches were underground in the ex-Communist country of **Ethiopia**. No longer – not only is the church out in the open it has grown exponentially. Today, the Ethiopian church is shaping up to be one of the great missionary forces at the turn of the millennium. The Evangelical Body has now grown to eight million believers and the revival going on in the Orthodox Church is now estimated to have seen 200,000 come to personal faith

National leaders in Ethiopia are currently working through a four-phase development of a national plan and strategy for evangelism and missions in Ethiopia, the Horn of Africa and the world over the next 20 years – yes 20 years, but they plan to complete the penetration of all peoples in the Horn of Africa by 2000. For the 1-6 June 1998 meeting they will bring together 200 selected leaders for a national evangelism and missions planning and strategy workshop.

Kyrgyzstan, one of the new Central Asian states to emerge from the old USSR. It is often called the Switzerland of Central Asia with good reason; range after range of the high Tien Shan mountains corrugate the country and provide it with good supplies of water. However, the economy of the country is in collapse. Huge potential, but influenced by the breakdown of communications, the infrastructure and the pervading dominance of the Mafia networks. However, in the midst of it all God is working. The first Kyrgyz came to Jesus in 1986, but today there may be nearly 4,000 Christians among them.

I have just completed an 8-page booklet on the **Arabian Peninsula**. Having visited the majority of the countries in the Peninsula last year and seeking the amazing things God was doing, I was asked to write it up. As I sought to gather the facts with careful review by those within, I was astounded to discover reports of so many secret believers. But the Holy Spirit has done another thing there – bringing people from so many countries. For example, in the UAE 75% of the people are internationals. Among the internationals in the Gulf there are tens of thousands of vital believers in Christ.

Right across the 10/40 Window the church is experiencing an amazing explosive kind of numerical growth over the last 50 years and especially in the years of this decade.

II. The Move of Satan in the 10/40 Window

The very name Satan means adversary. Satan's avowed purpose is to thwart the plan of God in every area and by every means possible. The Scripture makes this clear in 1 Pet. 5:8 "Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour." Satan blinds their minds so that they will not accept the gospel (2 Co 4:4)

In order to promote this opposition, Satan can appear like a wily serpent (Rev 12:9), or a ferocious dragon (Rev 12:3), or an attractive angel of light (2 Co 11:14).

More Christians have died for their faith in this century than in all the previous history of Christendom combined. According to World Mission Digest there are some 100 million martyrs in this so called modern 20th Century. More people have died in circumstances related to their faith in this century than in all the 20th Century wars combined. The problem is getting worse rather than getting better.

Every indication is that Satan has moved in the world and especially in the 10/40 Window to oppose the advance of the Gospel.

Christian Solidarity International is a global interdenominational organization which defends the human rights of persecuted
Christians and other victims of repression. They have developed a map showing the countries with restricted human rights in colors on four levels. The darker the color the fewer human rights. For the three levels with the lowest level of human rights you will find all the countries in the 10/40 Window. Satan has established a stronghold in the 10/40 Window, but every indication is that this grip is loosening—but still it causes great affliction.

In the communist countries of China, North Korea and Vietnam and in the countries where the radical strains of Islam have influence, Christians are daily facing persecution and martyrdom. When we think of persecution, we are thinking about being beaten, raped, robbed, dispossessed, imprisoned unjustifiably, enslaved and killed. In speaking about persecution and discrimination we are talking primarily about 60 countries around the world. This is a serious global problem and unfortunately, a growing trend of our day.

"Here is a call for the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and hold fast to the faith of Jesus" (Rev. 14:12).

In Iran in May 1996 a new wave of persecution began and as a result pastors and Christians have been arrested, interrogated and executed. Christians are forbidden to contact the outside world and ordered to constantly report to the Ministry of Information. Many Muslim converts have lost their jobs and are under heavy surveillance.

In the West Bank and Gaza Muslim believers are suffering serious persecution at this time.

Traveling at night, preaching and speaking during the day, **Chinese** house church pastors work in one of the world's most dangerous vineyards. They endure the possibility of arrest by a hostile government, yet they give their lives to strengthen and build up the body of Christ. Holding a house meeting of Christian believers is illegal. Those who are caught are often tortured, using boiling water to burn them in order to force confessions of loyalty to the Chinese Communist government. Many who are

arrested are sent to prison labor camps where they are often denied food and water and are shocked with electric probes. Amazingly, people still come to these home fellowships where they can hear the word of God proclaimed and share life with other believers.

Christians have been called on to back an urgent call for prayer by well-known Chinese house church leader Lin Xanga the leader of a large, unregistered house church in Guangzhou in southern China, which attracts up to two thousand people per week, who has expressed fears a crackdown against unregistered churches in China.

He reported that on February 10 three officials from the Guangzhou Religious Affairs Bureau visited him at his house church. They handed him a copy of the "Laws Controlling Religious Affairs for Guangzhou Municipality" dated December 28, 1997 and told him to study them.

The pastor, who has spent 20 years in prison for his faith, told the officials he would not register the church. He pointed out that in the "White Paper on the Situation of Freedom of Religious Belief in **China**" issued by the Chinese government last October, it clearly states in Section Three that "house meetings do not have to register". He pointed out that national laws take precedent over local legislation.

The United Nations reports that the militant Islamic government of central African **Sudan** has declared a systematic battle against Christians. Since 1982, 300,000 Sudanese Christians have been killed. Each year hundreds of Christian believers are sold into slavery and taken where they have to work as slaves or as concubines for their Muslim masters. “Please pray for us," Sudanese Christian leaders urge believers around the world, "we need your prayer support so that we might be able to love those who cause our sufferings and show them that the love of Christ is a stronger weapon than those used against us."

The government of **Vietnam** has set out on a course of oppressive brutality aimed at wiping out the Gospel and the Christian Church. Christians who profess their faith openly without submitting to government control have been arrested, imprisoned and sentenced to "cultural re-education.'

As we look for a trend, neither the Scriptures nor the reports from around the world suggest that things are going to improve but rather get worse. The Scripture describes a future scene in heaven in Rev. 12 7 “And there was war in heaven. Michael and his angels fought against the dragon, and the dragon and his angels fought back. 8 But he was not strong enough, and they lost their place in heaven. 9 The great dragon was hurled down—that ancient serpent called the devil, or Satan, who leads the whole world astray. He was hurled to the earth, and his angels with him.” Then verse 12 reads “He is filled with fury, because he knows that his time is short.”

In **India**, persecution has been intense in some of the states of India. The Christian population in Arunachal Pradesh has grown in the last 10 years from 4.32% in 1981 to 10.29% in 1991 in spite of severe opposition and persecution. The government of Maharashtra has ordered the deportation of three foreign missionaries for leading eleven tribals to Christ. There has been a strong revival and significant people movement among the eight million-member Gond tribe, with many coming to faith in Christ. This has led to sporadic persecution and mob attacks by screaming Hindus, chanting their opposition to this "foreign religion."

New national persecution of enormous proportions could break out on a national scale with the results of the latest elections. The results of the recent elections to the Indian parliament have been declared;

the Hindu fascist party Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its allies have led the way.

The militant arm of the BJP, the RSS ended a three-day closed-door strategic meeting in November 1997 with plans to make India a Hindu nation. Among the things discussed were steps to counter the activities of Christians in the country by strengthening co-ordination among the (BJP) and other pro-Hindu organizations. The RSS also plans to open 500 schools in the state of Orissa to neutralize what it called the activities of Christians and promote the re-conversion of converted tribals.

The joint general-secretary of the RSS, Mr. Sudarshan, said one of the resolutions passed was to give the BJP the freedom to capture and retain national power by the year 2002 and realize the dream of making India a Hindu country. Mr. Sudarshan also predicted that in the 21st century there would be "an explosion of Hindutva (Hindu culture) across the world" that would re-unite the divided India.

The RSS web site on the Internet goes into considerable detail on their agenda and makes the following accusation about Christianity: "Christian missionary efforts at proselytization have now become far more widespread and insidious. In all, about 100,000 missionaries - 9,400 foreign and the rest local - are now engaged in divisive and subversive activities under the mask of various kinds of service projects."

The Scripture calls the Christian to Persevere in the Faith, Hastening the Day of Messiah's Return (2 Peter 3:9-12).

III. The Move of the Church in the 10/40 Window

A. The prayer moves of the global church toward the 10/40 Window

The prayer for this region of the world has been amazing! With the hope of perhaps one million in October 1993 some 20 million Christians from 1200 local churches from different parts of the world prayed county by country through all the countries of the 10/40 Window. On-site intercessory teams came to each of the countries for days of prayer walking, asking God for a spiritual breakthrough to take place. Millions of others worldwide joined in the concerted prayer effort.

In 1995, building upon the prayer momentum of 1993, prayer focused on the 100 gateway cities of the 10/40 Window. The commitment was beyond expectation as over 36 million were reported to have participated. Then in 1997 the focus moved to the unreached peoples of the 10/40 Window and again the commitment was so massive that written reports are still coming in. "Praying through the Window IV—Light the Window" in October 1999 may well be the most powerful and effective effort to date.

When a well-respected international worker in the area commented that he anticipated a spiritual harvest in the Arab world in the near future, I asked him: "Why?" He answered: "Growing awareness and prayers of the saints around the world."

B. The people move of the global church toward the 10/40 Window

When we pray to the Lord of the Harvest to thrust out laborers to the harvest field sometime, He thrusts out the very ones who were praying that prayer. It appears that this is what is happening. Interest in short- and long-term teams to countries within the 10/40 Window, from others within the 10/40 Window and from outside have dramatically increased. For example, in the Philippines they are consciously focusing on sending and supporting efforts into the 10/40 Window. Already they have 1000 missionaries, many focusing on the 10/40 window. As a result of their efforts one of the largest churches in the Arabian Peninsula is pastored by a Filipino. They are having a major impact in the country of

Myanmar today.

Joshua Project 2000 is a global effort of the church to seek to establish a church planting effort of at least 100 people in every one of the peoples of the world over 10,000. The total population of these almost 2000 distinct people lie in the 10/40 Window. There have been three basic phases of Joshua Project 2000. Phase one was to determine a widely agreed-upon priority list of least evangelized ethno-linguistic peoples with populations greater than 10,000, less than 2% evangelical and less than 5% Christian adherent. The list has continually undergone refinement to emerging realities. Numerous Peoples have been removed from or added to this list as better information has given a clearer picture of their status. Phase two was to determine which of the groups on the list had a reported church-planting effort in their midst. After gathering nearly 30,000 pieces of information from 80 countries, the encouraging result was to find that there were about 800 of the approximately 2000 without a church planting effort. Through this process groups were that remained 'unclaimed' were identified. Unclaimed groups have no reported church planting effort in their midst and do not have a reported mission agency pledging church planting in the near future. Most of these were claimed in the course of the global consultation (GCOWE 97) held in South Africa last July. Now the third phase is being conducted to determine the status of the indigenous church among these Peoples. While step two measured exposure, this third step seeks to measure response; what is the result of the church planting efforts? The minimum goal of the Joshua Project is to see a pioneer church-planting movement resulting in 100 or more Christians in one or more reproducing fellowships. It is encouraging to see the progress and commitment of the global church toward planting the church among the unreached peoples of the 10/40 Window and beyond.

C. The process moves of the global church toward the 10/40 Window

The question being asked today in many Christian organizations and in relation to the unfinished task and the 10/40 Window is "What is the most effective process for the Church worldwide to complete the unfinished task?" From here I leave for Norway, where Christian leaders have called for a forum to deal with that question specifically as it relates to the most effective way to work together for the Great Commission. Please pray for us as we gather!

Let us follow Paul's counsel to prepare God's people for works of service, so that the body of Christ may be built up until we all reach unity in the faith … and become mature, attaining to the whole measure of the fullness of Christ.… Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into him who is the Head, that is, Christ. From him the whole body, joined and held together by every supporting ligament, grows and builds itself up in love, as each part does its work. Amen!

In summary, three evolutionary process steps are being taken that suggest a powerful trend is emerging which is increasing the effectiveness of world evangelization.

1. Organizational renewal to focus on the unreached

Again, it was John Naisbitt who wrote in *Megatrends 2000*: "The year 2000 is operating like a powerful magnet on humanity, already reaching down into the 1990's and intensifying the decade. It is amplifying emotions, accelerating change, and heightening awareness, compelling us to re-examine ourselves, our values and our institutions…"

The largest evangelical organization in the world in this last year exemplifies this new reality. They have totally restructured in these last years as we approach the year 2000 to focus on reaching the unreached peoples in the 10/40 Window. Beyond 2000 undoubtedly this trend will pick up. We are all being called

to re-examine our structures. I remember the last time I was in Norway, one of the largest missions—the Norwegian Santal Mission, under Torbjorn Lied who also chairs the Norwegian Missionary Council, spoke of the complete renewal of his mission to focus on the unfinished task. Praise God!

2. People and country-specific Networking, alliances and partnership

In the process of networking we have discovered that the principle of working together rather than each entity on its own is much more effective. We have discovered that there is wide variety of kinds of networks and coalitions and movements and partnerships. Some are embedded in primary unshakable principles such as intentional partnerships, international partnerships, integrated partnerships. Others, seeking to accomplish the same thing do not insist on adherence to rigid standards. They call themselves strategic alliances that are strategic both because of their focus and their approach to the task. Some ride on the wave of technological advance with e-mail conference networks. Some are field-based seeking to advance God's Kingdom on the ground. Others are resource-based seeking to generate and supply greater resources for the task. Some are strategic networks in that they seek to advance certain strategic functions such as prayer, women in missions, cities, business and professionals, presidents and academic deans of theological institutions. Others are countrywide coalitions seeking to advance the purposes of Christ in a country. Some are people-specific networks that have the common focus on peoples.

3. Flexible leadership style to complete the unfinished task

From the current trend with regard to effective organizational development emerges effective organizational development for the post 2000 AD world. Organizational development that grows in effectiveness in the nineties can be characterized by a series of contrasts. The flexible leadership style model emphasizes personal relationship over positional relationship. The focus of loyalty has shifted from institution to people. The style is less structured – more flexible. The source of energy rather than from stability comes instead from change and innovation. Instead of leadership being dogmatic, authoritative it is inspirational, empowering, enabling, facilitating. The leader rather than giving orders coaches, teaches. Instead of the quality depending on the affordable best it calls forth excellence. Expectations for associates are not for security but rather personal growth. Status does not come from title and rank but from making a difference. What are considered resources are not so much cash and time but rather information, people and networks. This is the wave of the future—beyond 2000.

Conclusion:

We see the move of God the Holy Spirit in powerful ways in the 10/40 Window as a trend of our times. However, we also observe the move of Satan to oppose the advance of God in the 10/40 Window as a trend of our times. And third, we discern that the Church worldwide is moving into the 10/40 Window with prayer, with people and with the process of working together in renewed organizations with a more flexible style of leadership.

Then I heard a loud voice in heaven say: "Now have come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God, and the authority of his Christ. For the accuser of our brothers, who accuses them before our God day and night, has been hurled down. They overcame him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony; they did not love their lives so much as to shrink from death. (Rev. 12:10-11)